of Ratan's restructuring programme and decided not to be associated with it. In February 1995, Kerkar decided that the IHCL would not participate in the JRD Quality Value (QV) Award introduced by Ratan. While Ratan was 'reluctant' to 'lose the Taj from the list of participants', he was also hesitant to 'debate the point further' with Kerkar.

Another point of difference between Ratan and Kerkar emerged when the Brand Equity programme that entailed the use of the Tata brand name came up for implementation. The royalty payment for the use of the Tata brand name was an integral part of the programme. Ratan wrote to Kerkar informing him of the proposal and the need for its implementation. While the IHCL board and its subsidiaries had approved the proposal, he hoped to receive Kerkar's 'active support in the implementation of this new policy' and requested a 'line of confirmation' from him. Kerkar opposed the royalty payment for use of the Tata name. He also brushed aside Ratan's idea to incorporate the 'Tata' name in the Indian Hotels brand. He stated that IHCL did not owe anything to the Tatas, apart from the fact that Jamsetji Tata had set up the first hotel a hundred-odd years ago.

These were not the only areas of difference. When Ratan requested Kerkar to help out by buying shares of Tata Sons worth Rs 10 crore, the latter declined. Another difference between them arose regarding the acquisition price of India Tourism Development Corporation (ITDC) shares by IHCL from its associate companies. Ratan objected to the way the price was approved and wrote to Kerkar that the transaction had been 'pushed through', and that the 'purchase price being paid by IHCL was too high and that such a profit to the associate companies was not justified'. He also felt that some company officials had primed a prominent IHCL shareholder to vehemently oppose the Tata brand equity scheme.

But despite their different perceptions on many issues, Ratan reached out to Kerkar for support for his restructuring initiatives. The chairman commented that they had different approaches to issues because they had not understood each other well. He wrote to Kerkar to 'avoid this kind of needless misunderstanding' and suggested he 'reduce the distance and lack of contact' between them. With Kerkar responding to the letter, it finally seemed like the two might have buried the hatchet.

Ratan also sought Kerkar's views regarding the latter's possible successors, as the Taj veteran would attain retirement age of sixty-five on 25 April 1997. He wrote to Kerkar on 8 October 1996 requesting him to